

IT Project Manager

Interview Preparation Guide

Simple explanations with examples. Read before your interview.

This guide explains every requirement from the job description. For each topic, you will find: a simple explanation, why it matters, a possible interview question, and a sample answer you can use. Practice saying the sample answers out loud before your interview.

PART 1: CANDIDATE REQUIREMENTS

Topic 1: Higher Education

What is this?

The job requires a university degree in management, economics, applied mathematics, information technologies, computer science, engineering, or business analytics. This means you studied a subject that is related to the job. A PM needs both business knowledge (to understand what the company needs) and technical knowledge (to understand how IT systems work). Your degree in Applied Mathematics from Baku State University is a perfect match because mathematics teaches logical thinking and problem solving.

Why is it important?

Employers want to see that you have a strong educational foundation. A university degree shows that you can study, analyze information, and complete complex tasks. For IT Project Management, both business and technical degrees are accepted.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "What is your educational background and how does it relate to this position?"

Sample Answer:

"I have a Bachelor of Science in Applied Mathematics from Baku State University. Mathematics taught me analytical thinking, logical problem solving, and data analysis. These skills are essential for project management because a PM must analyze problems, make data-driven decisions, and think logically. Additionally, my 15 years of software engineering experience gave me deep technical knowledge that helps me understand IT projects from both business and technical perspectives."

Tip: Always connect your education to the job. Explain HOW your degree helps you as a PM.

Topic 2: IT Project Management Experience (Minimum 1 Year)

What is this?

The job requires at least 1 year of experience in IT project management. This means you have led or managed at least one IT project from start to finish. Experience includes: planning a project, coordinating a team, tracking progress, managing risks, and delivering results. In your case, you have 2+ years of project delivery experience at Embafinans and Birbonus. You managed projects like credit scoring systems, payment gateway integration, and loyalty bonus systems.

Why is it important?

Project management experience shows that you can handle real-world challenges. It is not enough to know theory. Employers want to see that you have actually managed projects, solved problems, and delivered results. Your experience at Embafinans demonstrates that you can manage cross-functional teams and deliver production systems.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "Tell me about your IT project management experience."

Sample Answer:

"I have over 2 years of hands-on project delivery experience in fintech. At Embafinans, I led the delivery of 4 major projects: a BNPL Credit Scoring system that reduced credit decision time by 50%, a B2C Sales Channel processing 300-500 daily applications, a real-time delivery tracking dashboard, and an end-to-end credit lifecycle platform. In each project, I managed scope, coordinated cross-functional teams, tracked progress using Jira, and ensured on-time delivery. Before that, at Birbonus, I led the design and delivery of a customer loyalty bonus system."

Tip: Use numbers and results in your answer. Say "300-500 applications" not just "many applications".

Topic 3: Agile, Scrum, Waterfall and Power BI

What is this?

These are methodologies and tools that a PM uses every day. Agile means working in short cycles (sprints). Instead of planning everything at the beginning, you plan a little, build a little, test a little, and repeat. Scrum is a type of Agile. It has specific roles (Scrum Master, Product Owner, Team), events (Sprint Planning, Daily Standup, Sprint Review, Retrospective), and artifacts (Product Backlog, Sprint Backlog, Burndown Chart). Waterfall is the traditional approach: you plan everything first, then build, then test, then deliver. Each phase must finish before the next one starts. Power BI is a Microsoft tool for creating visual dashboards and reports from data. A PM uses Power BI to show project status, KPIs, and trends to stakeholders.

Why is it important?

Every IT company uses Agile or Scrum today. Waterfall is used for projects with fixed requirements (like government projects). Power BI is increasingly required because stakeholders want visual reports, not text documents.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "Which project management methodologies have you used?"

Sample Answer:

"In my projects at Embafinans, I primarily used Agile and Scrum methodologies. We worked in 2-week sprints with Sprint Planning at the start, Daily Standups for coordination, and Sprint Reviews to demonstrate completed features to stakeholders. I used Jira for sprint boards, burndown charts, and backlog management. For stakeholder reporting, I created Power BI dashboards that showed project KPIs like application volume, error rates, and team velocity. This gave stakeholders a clear visual view of project status without reading long text reports."

Tip: If they ask about Waterfall, say: "I understand Waterfall and can use it when requirements are fixed and well-defined. However, Agile is my preferred approach for IT projects because it allows flexibility and faster feedback."

Topic 4: Analytical Thinking and Problem Solving

What is this?

Analytical thinking means you can look at a problem, break it into smaller parts, understand the root cause, and find a solution. Problem solving means you do not just identify problems but actually fix them. For example, if a project is delayed, an analytical PM will find out WHY (is it a technical issue? a resource issue? a scope issue?) and then propose a solution (add more developers? remove some features? extend the deadline?).

Why is it important?

This is one of the most important skills for a PM. Every project has problems. A PM who can analyze and solve problems quickly keeps the project on track.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "Give me an example of a problem you solved in a project."

Sample Answer:

"During the BNPL Credit Scoring project, we faced conflicting stakeholder priorities. The risk team wanted stricter rules, while the sales team wanted faster approvals. I analyzed the situation using SQL data queries to understand the actual default rates and approval patterns. Based on the data, I proposed a balanced solution: medium-risk applications could be auto-approved while high-risk ones required manual review. This satisfied both teams and we achieved 2x faster credit decisions."

Tip: Always mention DATA in your answer. Employers love PMs who make decisions based on data, not feelings.

Topic 5: Project Planning, Budget and Resource Management

What is this?

Project Planning means creating a roadmap for the project: What are the goals? What tasks need to be done? Who will do each task? When will each task be completed? What are the milestones (important dates)? Budget Management means tracking how much money the project uses. Every project has a money limit. The PM must check regularly: Are we spending more than planned? If yes, why? How can we fix it? Resource Management means managing people and tools. Who is working on what? Does anyone have too much work? Does anyone have too little work? Are we using our tools and licenses efficiently?

Why is it important?

A project without planning will fail. Without budget management, the project will cost too much. Without resource management, the team will be overloaded or underutilized. These three skills together ensure that a project finishes on time, within budget, and with the right use of resources.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "How do you plan a project and manage its budget and resources?"

Sample Answer:

"I start by defining the project scope and goals with stakeholders. Then I break the project into tasks using a work breakdown structure, assign tasks to team members, and set milestones in Jira. For budget management, I track delivery costs and resource usage weekly, aligned with project timelines, ensuring optimal use of available budget. For resource management, I distribute team members across concurrent projects based on priority and capacity. For example, when we had Credit Scoring and Payment Gateway projects running simultaneously, I allocated 2 developers to the higher-priority project and 1 to the other, while sharing QA resources."

Tip: "Budget" does not always mean direct money. Time and people are also resources that have cost.

Topic 6: Priority Setting

What is this?

Priority setting means deciding which tasks or features are most important and should be done first. When you have 20 tasks but only time for 10, you must choose the most valuable ones. There are frameworks for this. The most common ones are: RICE Framework: Reach (how many users will benefit?), Impact (how much value?), Confidence (how sure are we?), Effort (how much time/money?). $\text{Score} = (\text{R} \times \text{I} \times \text{C}) / \text{E}$. MoSCoW Method: Must have (critical), Should have (important), Could have (nice), Won't have (not this time). Eisenhower Matrix: Urgent+Important (do now), Important+Not Urgent (plan), Urgent+Not Important (delegate), Not Urgent+Not Important (skip).

Why is it important?

A PM must set priorities every day. If priorities are wrong, the team works on low-value tasks while important tasks are delayed. Good priority setting = maximum business value with limited time and resources.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "How do you prioritize tasks and requirements?"

Sample Answer:

"I use the RICE framework to prioritize requirements. For each requirement, I evaluate Reach (how many users or stakeholders benefit), Impact (how much business value it creates), Confidence (how certain we are about our estimates), and Effort (how much time and resources it needs). Then I calculate the RICE score and rank requirements by score. This ensures that our sprint planning focuses on the highest-value tasks. I also use the MoSCoW method to classify requirements into Must, Should, Could, and Won't categories for clear scope management."

Tip: Write RICE on paper and remember: Reach x Impact x Confidence / Effort.

Topic 7: PM Certifications (PMP, Scrum Master)

What is this?

The job description says PMP, Scrum Master, or other PM certifications are an advantage. PMP (Project Management Professional) is a global certification from PMI. It covers all aspects of project management: planning, executing, monitoring, closing. It requires 35 hours of training and 3-5 years of experience. Scrum Master (CSM or PSM) is a certification for Scrum methodology. It shows that you understand Agile/Scrum roles, events, and artifacts. It is easier and faster to get than PMP. Other certifications: CAPM (entry-level PM), PRINCE2 (popular in Europe), ITIL (service management), PMI-ACP (Agile certified practitioner).

Why is it important?

Certifications show that you have formal knowledge of project management. They are not always required, but they give you an advantage over other candidates, especially when experience levels are similar.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "Do you have any PM certifications?"

Sample Answer:

"While I do not currently hold a formal PM certification, I have extensive hands-on experience applying PM best practices in real projects. I am actively preparing for the PMP certification and have been studying the PMBOK guide. My daily work at Embafinans already involves all the core PM competencies that these certifications test: scope management, stakeholder management, risk management, and Agile methodologies. I plan to complete my PMP certification in the near future."

Tip: If you do not have a certificate, say you are studying for one. This shows motivation.

Topic 8: Teamwork and Responsibility

What is this?

Teamwork means you can work well with other people: developers, testers, business analysts, managers, and stakeholders. A PM does not work alone. The PM connects all team members and makes sure everyone works toward the same goal. Responsibility means you take ownership of your work and your project. If something goes wrong, you do not blame others. You take responsibility, find the problem, and fix it. If a project succeeds, you share the credit with the team.

Why is it important?

IT projects are always team efforts. A PM who cannot work with people will fail, even with perfect technical skills. Employers look for PMs who can build trust, resolve conflicts, and keep the team motivated.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "How do you work with teams and handle responsibility?"

Sample Answer:

"In my role, I work with cross-functional teams every day: developers, QA engineers, business analysts, risk managers, and operations teams. I facilitate alignment meetings to ensure everyone understands the project goals and their responsibilities. I believe in transparent communication and regular status updates. When issues arise, I take responsibility for finding solutions rather than assigning blame. For example, during UAT testing, when we found critical bugs, I immediately organized a bug triage meeting with QA and developers to prioritize and assign fixes, rather than pointing fingers."

Tip: Use words like "facilitate," "coordinate," "align" instead of "boss" or "command".

PART 2: JOB RESPONSIBILITIES

Topic 9: Defining Project Goals and Execution Strategy

What is this?

This means the PM must answer: What is this project trying to achieve? (Goals) How will we achieve it? (Strategy). Goals should be SMART: Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound. Strategy means creating a plan that includes: phases of the project, key milestones, team structure, risk assessment, and success criteria.

Why is it important?

Without clear goals, the team does not know what they are building. Without a strategy, the team does not know HOW to build it. The PM must define both at the start and communicate them to everyone.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "How do you define project goals and strategy?"

Sample Answer:

"I start by conducting stakeholder sessions to understand what the business needs. Then I define SMART goals: for example, instead of 'improve credit decisions,' I would say 'reduce credit decision time from 24 hours to 12 hours by

March 2025." For strategy, I create a phased plan with clear milestones: Phase 1 is discovery and scope definition, Phase 2 is development, Phase 3 is UAT testing, and Phase 4 is go-live. I also define success criteria so we know when the project is complete."

Topic 10: Monitoring Tasks and Coordinating the Team

What is this?

This means the PM checks: Is each team member doing their tasks? Are tasks on schedule? Are there any blockers? The PM uses tools like Jira to see task status daily. Coordination means making sure all team members work together smoothly. If the backend developer finishes an API, the frontend developer needs to know so they can start integration. The PM connects people.

Why is it important?

A PM who does not monitor tasks will discover problems too late. A PM who does not coordinate the team will have developers waiting for each other and wasting time.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "How do you monitor tasks and coordinate your team?"

Sample Answer:

"I use Jira as my primary tool for task monitoring. Every morning, I check the sprint board and burndown chart to see: Which tasks are completed? Which are in progress? Which are blocked? For team coordination, I organize daily standup meetings where each team member answers 3 questions: What did I do yesterday? What will I do today? Is anything blocking me? If there is a blocker, I immediately work on removing it. I also ensure that when one team member finishes a task (like API development), the next person (like frontend integration) is ready to start."

Topic 11: Tracking Project Progress and Managing Risks

What is this?

Progress Tracking: The PM regularly checks: Are we on schedule? Are we within budget? Are we meeting quality standards? This is done through status reports, dashboards, and meetings with stakeholders. Risk Management: A risk is something that MIGHT go wrong in the future. For example: a key developer might leave, a server might crash, requirements might change. The PM must: identify risks early, assess their impact (high/medium/low), plan mitigation actions (what will we do if the risk happens?), and monitor risks throughout the project.

Why is it important?

Without progress tracking, the PM does not know if the project is on track until it is too late. Without risk management, the PM reacts to problems instead of preventing them.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "How do you track progress and manage risks?"

Sample Answer:

"For progress tracking, I generate weekly sprint reports in Jira showing completed tasks, remaining tasks, burndown velocity, and any deviations from the plan. I share these with stakeholders in weekly status meetings. For risk management, I maintain a risk register that lists all identified risks, their probability and impact, and mitigation plans. For example, during the Credit Lifecycle project, I identified the risk of changing regulations as high-impact. My mitigation plan was to

maintain flexibility in the scoring rules so we could adjust quickly. I review the risk register weekly and update it as needed."

Topic 12: Effective Stakeholder Communication and Reporting

What is this?

Stakeholders are all the people who care about the project: managers, business owners, developers, testers, end users. The PM must communicate with all of them regularly. Communication means: sharing good news AND bad news, asking for decisions when needed, managing expectations (what is possible and what is not), and resolving conflicts between different stakeholders. Reporting means creating status reports, dashboards, and presentations that show project progress. Good reports are clear, concise, and visual.

Why is it important?

Poor communication is the #1 cause of project failure. If stakeholders do not know what is happening, they make wrong decisions. If the PM does not manage expectations, stakeholders will be disappointed even if the project is successful.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "How do you communicate with stakeholders and create reports?"

Sample Answer:

"I believe in proactive and transparent communication. I schedule regular meetings with different stakeholder groups: weekly status meetings with managers, sprint reviews with the development team, and UAT coordination meetings with business users. For reporting, I create Power BI dashboards that show key metrics visually, combined with written status summaries for context. When there is bad news, I share it early along with a proposed solution. I find that stakeholders appreciate honesty and action-oriented communication more than hidden problems."

Topic 13: IT Project Planning, Management and Coordination

What is this?

This combines all the PM skills: planning (scope, timeline, resources), management (tracking, controlling, adjusting), and coordination (connecting people, managing dependencies). For IT projects specifically, the PM also needs to understand technical concepts: software development lifecycle, API integration, testing, deployment, and infrastructure. Your 15+ years of engineering background gives you a significant advantage here because you can understand technical discussions and make informed decisions.

Why is it important?

IT projects are more complex than other projects because technology changes fast and technical issues are harder to predict. A PM who understands technology can better plan, estimate, and manage IT projects.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "What makes IT project management different from other project management?"

Sample Answer:

"IT projects have unique challenges: requirements often change during development, technical dependencies between systems can cause delays, and testing requires specialized environments. My 15 years of software engineering experience helps me understand these challenges. For example, when a developer says an API integration will take 2 weeks, I can evaluate if that estimate is realistic based on my technical background. This helps me create more accurate plans and

manage stakeholder expectations better than a non-technical PM could."

Tip: Your 15 years engineering background is your BIGGEST advantage. Always mention it.

Topic 14: Efficient Resource and Budget Management

What is this?

Resource Management: Resources include people (developers, testers, analysts), tools (Jira licenses, servers, Power BI), and time (hours, days, sprints). The PM must ensure resources are used efficiently: no one is overloaded, no one is idle, tools are not wasted, and time is used productively. Budget Management: Budget is the money available for the project. The PM tracks planned vs actual spending. Key terms: Cost Estimation (predicting costs before project starts), Cost Tracking (monitoring spending during project), Budget Variance (difference between planned and actual costs).

Why is it important?

Efficient resource management saves money and time. Good budget management prevents projects from running out of money before completion. These are core PM competencies that every employer expects.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "How do you manage resources and budget in your projects?"

Sample Answer:

"I manage resources by distributing team members across projects based on priority and capacity. For example, when we had multiple projects running at Embafinans, I used Jira to track each developer's workload and ensure no one was overloaded. I also used the RICE framework to prioritize tasks so the team always works on the highest-value items. For budget management, I track delivery costs aligned with project timelines and monitor weekly whether we are within planned budget. If I see a potential over-budget situation, I immediately analyze the cause and propose corrective actions to management."

Topic 15: Implementing PMIS and New Project Management Approaches

What is this?

PMIS (Project Management Information System) is a software system that helps a PM manage all project information in one place. The most popular PMIS tools in IT are: Jira: For Agile projects. Sprint boards, backlog, burndown charts, velocity tracking. MS Project: For Waterfall projects. Gantt charts, critical path analysis. Asana / Monday.com: For general project management. Task boards, timelines. A PMIS gives you visibility: you can see all tasks, all risks, all resources, and all costs in one dashboard. Without a PMIS, a PM uses Excel and email, which is slow and error-prone. New approaches mean the PM should always look for better ways to manage projects: new tools, new processes, new methodologies.

Why is it important?

A PMIS makes a PM more efficient and organized. It also provides transparency because stakeholders can see project status themselves. Implementing new approaches shows that the PM is proactive and always improving.

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "What PMIS tools have you used and how?"

Sample Answer:

"I implemented Jira-based project management workflows for sprint planning, task tracking, burndown reporting, and milestone management. I set up sprint boards for each project, configured burndown charts to monitor velocity, and created dashboards for stakeholders. Jira served as our PMIS, giving the entire team and stakeholders real-time visibility into project progress. I also used Confluence for documentation, which integrated with Jira for requirement traceability."

Topic 16: Test Strategy, Risk Management and Change Management

What is this?

Test Strategy: A plan that defines HOW a project will be tested before go-live. It answers: What will we test? (features, reports, payments) When? (after development) Who? (QA team, business users) How? (manual, automated, UAT). The PM participates in test strategy planning and coordinates UAT with business stakeholders. **Risk Management:** Identifying what might go wrong, assessing impact, and planning mitigation. Risks are tracked in a risk register. **Change Management:** Handling changes DURING a project. When someone says "please add this new feature," the PM must analyze the impact on time and budget, get approval, and update the plan. Without change management, scope creep happens (the project keeps growing and never finishes).

Why is it important?

These three skills together ensure that the final product is high quality (test strategy), problems are prevented (risk management), and the project stays on track despite changes (change management).

Possible Interview Question:

Q: "Tell me about your experience with test strategy, risks, and change management."

Sample Answer:

"I participated in test strategy planning alongside QA teams. I helped define test scope, coordinated UAT execution with business stakeholders, and led bug triage meetings to prioritize fixes. For risk management, I maintained a risk register and reviewed it weekly. For change management, when stakeholders requested changes, I analyzed the impact on timeline and resources, presented options to management, and after approval, updated the project plan and added new tasks to Jira. This structured approach prevented scope creep and kept the project focused on agreed objectives."

FINAL INTERVIEW TIPS

1. Use the STAR Method: S (Situation) = What was the problem? T (Task) = What did you need to do? A (Action) = What did YOU do? R (Result) = What was the outcome? Every answer should follow this structure.
2. Use Numbers: "300-500 applications" is better than "many applications." Numbers show measurable impact.
3. Connect Everything to Your Experience: When they ask about theory, always give an example from Embafinans, Birbonus, or Umico.
4. Be Honest: If you do not know something, say: "I have basic knowledge and I am learning more." Then connect it to what you DO know.
5. Speak Confidently: Your 15+ years of engineering background is a significant advantage. Not many PMs have deep technical knowledge.
6. Ask Questions: At the end, ask about the team structure, current projects, and challenges. This shows interest and preparation.